

Stone Age sculpture

Long before humans invented writing, they created art. The oldest art so far found was made around 38,000 BCE, in the Stone Age Upper Palaeolithic period, and was probably connected to belief systems. Some of the earliest art was three-dimensional: small stone, ivory or bone female figures known as Venus figurines (although far predating the Roman myth) are the best known. Found in various parts of the world, they all share similar physical attributes, including short legs and arms and exaggerated breasts, bellies and thighs, suggesting that they may have been fertility icons. The most famous is the 11 cm (4¼ in) limestone *Venus of Willendorf* from Austria, made c.28,000–25,000 BCE.

As well as humans, Stone Age sculptors carved animals. South Korean figures carved on deer bone have been dated to around 38,000 BCE, and were probably good luck charms. The oldest known anthropomorphic carving is the *Lion Man of Hohlenstein Stadel* from Germany, a lion-headed human figure of similar age.



Venus of Willendorf, c.26,500 BCE